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In just a matter of a few weeks we'll move into a new year. For those of us in the world of education, it traditionally marks the halfway point of the school year. Though everyone else has their minds on starting from scratch, we're in the thick of things. For many forensic coaches, now is the time of year when you address what's working with your team and what exactly isn't.

A little introspection never hurt anyone.

Challenge your students to pick up the pace as we move down the stretch toward state tournaments, qualifiers, and (they'll be here before you know it) Nationals. The first semester doesn't really matter any more. Come January, you'll be rested and ready to go.

Okay, maybe the sense of renewal the new year brings isn't really all that different between forensicators and the real world.

That could very well be a first.

Best of luck as your season continues! It is my that 2007 is filled with fun adventure for both you and your program.

Corey Alderdice
Publisher

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Thrift

by Daschle Stephens

Humiliation has always played an integral part in self-discovery, and I suppose my life is no different. In my high school Intro to Drama class – we had to go around the room and introduce ourselves by telling everyone what animal we were most like. The other guys were panthers. They were grizzlies, lions, eagles, and boa constrictors – they were beasts of power, strength, and virility. Me? I was a squirrel. So while every other turbo-testosterone charged teen male was on the prowl – I was left open to a barrage of hi-larious innuendos about my "nuts". It never got old.

Now in my own defense, the squirrel thing isn't as asinine as it may sound. Growing up, money was tight around my house. We were by no means starving, but we had a healthy appreciation for what we had. Much like squirrels, my younger brother, Kevin, and I were always on the lookout to gather resources for home. If we were good during the week, my mom would take the two of us out to McDonald's for a family dinner on Friday. After finishing our Happy Meals, my brother and I would make sure to grab extra salt, pepper, and packets of "fancy ketchup" to take home for future dinners. At age 8 this ritual is charming and endearing. At age 28 you're called cheap by merciless friends and coworkers – to which I always respond, "Back off – my meatloaf is now delicious *and* fancy."

Sundays were always spent diving through the paper for the coupons and sale sections. Eventually my brother and I would create games to make the task of bargain hunting for mom a little more enjoyable. Sometimes we would compare products at different stores to see who had the best deals, and to make the stakes more interesting: the one with the lower price gave the other an Indian Sunburn or during the holidays – a delightful Texas Tittie Twister. Scissors askew - we flew like starving junkyard dogs through the sections. Kevin had an eye for office supplies and clothing sales but I always delivered a weekly whooping when it came to frozen foods and produce. Working two jobs to make ends meet, my mom appreciated the help though she never really saw the need to spend money on the frivolous things that kids find to be the most important. Case in point – neither Kevin nor I ever had a real lunchbox. And by real, I do mean the plastic box with a cartoon or action hero on the front. Mom figured that the plastic bags that we brought home our groceries in worked just fine. This never really bothered me, but it always seemed to irritate the other kids at school who felt the need to show off: A). The lunchboxes that their parents bought them and B). The unforgiving physics the thin bag had on my chips when met with someone's balled up fist before walking to the bathroom.

It was at this point that I usually emptied the contents of a packet of "fancy ketchup" into one of their open cans of Dr. Pepper. The projectile vomiting that followed would ensure the safety of my chips in the future. But this didn't stop my mom from trying to stencil Optimus Prime on my grocery bag the next day out of guilt.

*

If being thrifty made me the weird kid – it has also made me an awkward adult. As I move grudgingly through the end of my 20's, I still have the charm of Beaver Cleaver in the throes of puberty. My hair cowlicks in angles not found in advanced geometry classes, my clothes are so far from being name brand that the tags are blank, I can never find anything witty to say and I laugh like Pee-Wee Herman. Ladies…control yourselves. One good thing to come of my money conscious upbringing was the ability to crunch numbers freakishly well resulting in a passion for mathematics and yet another way to drive away the opposite sex. These days I work as a computer programmer at a faceless corporation. Sure, there are the same predator archetypes in the work place as there were in high school – but for every squirrel there are a dozen lions and panthers ready to bust my bushy behind into submission. There's a reason why you don't see many squirrels

in the Serengeti. But for the most part, that realization is fairly secure. My job isn't rocket science, but I get to play with numbers. I am virtually debt-free thanks to my fiscally conscious childhood and make a great salary that goes into savings for the future. While I don't go on weekly McDonald's binges, I still spend lazy Sunday afternoons browsing the coupon section. So my life isn't that thrilling. Granted, there are nights when I lie awake, stare at the ceiling, and dream of a life unchained from responsibility. I fantasize about windmills and giants. I drift to sleep hoping that life has more to offer than what I've been given.

I worked at the faceless corporation for three years without so much as a hiccup of anything exciting or interesting happening. But this was before the new girl entered the picture.

This was before Kristin ruined my life.

Okay, so ruined is a bit melodramatic – but anyone who has ever been hopelessly head over heels can relate. There are women in this world who are legendary in the minds of men. They are the women, who for reasons unknown inspire greatness. Kristin is beautiful – which is a glaring understatement. Kristin is stunning in that "I don't realize how gorgeous I am" way that few really pretty people are – which only made it worse for me. I however, was not the only one attracted to her, as almost every other guy in the office noticed it off the bat as well. After 2 months of working down the hall from me, I found myself uncontrollably intrigued by her. I watched her from across board rooms worried that if I looked away for too long she may disappear. Every inch of the woman fascinated me – from the way her mouth would uncurl like a ribbon into a beaming smile while her nose would scrunch up like a rabbit's. Her hair moved like water, and she would walk like a statuesque bombshell from a 60's cinema flick. Things she would do and say were captivating to me. She was the Helen of Troy to this gray faceless corporation. Long story short – Kristin wasn't out of my league, she was an entirely different sport.

At night, I would lie in bed and script out future encounters in my mind. During the day, I was mild mannered and socially awkward Mark. But at night and in my mind – I was suave and charming.

"Hello Kristin, darling."

"Oh Mark – I've been wait-"

"Shhh – we mustn't make the others jealous. Come with me now so that we may…do it."

But alas, life doesn't work like that. At least not my life, anyway. That never stops me from dreaming though.

*

The realities and responsibilities of life keep me chained to the ground. Sunday afternoon, I throw on my ultra-suede K-Mart sweatpants and vintage No Fear t-shirt to brave the grocery store. I find this to be the most exhilarating time to do my grocery shopping. While all of the macho men are at home watching football games – their wives are grocery shopping alongside bitter off old women and feral cat ladies. Now that I'm in my element – I am a predator. Armed with a fresh book of coupons bought off of a high school athletics fundraiser, I'm out for the kill. I whip through produce and canned goods like a Supermarket Sweep Champion and swing by the frozen food aisle before battling it out in the check-out lines when I hear,

"Hey – I know you…"

I stop dead in my tracks.

"We work in the same building, don't we?"

Kristin is standing by an open freezer door, smiling. She dressed in an old university t-shirt and baggy jeans with her hair pulled loosely into a ponytail. The t-shirt, being one size too small reveals the tiny thread of skin that I have come to call "The Kill Zone" – that area beneath a woman's navel and just above the band of her jeans. Women are armed with weapons such as the Kill Zone and men are left to commit acts of historical atrocity in its wake. Helen of Troy's Kill Zone is legendary.

"Yeah."

"How are you doing Mike?"

"Uh, it's Mark."

"Oh...sorry."

"That's alright, it happens all the time."

Actually it doesn't.

"I can be really oblivious."

She's also oblivious to the fact that the freezer door is still open and the cold air is wreaking havoc on her thin t-shirt. I hear my brain scream "EYES MAN! FOR THE LOVE OF GOD! EYES!" and I do everything in my power to keep from looking down.

"Kristin, right?"

"Yeah."

"So....Yeeahh"

Sweet God in Heaven. I think I was born without the part of the brain that makes small talk possible. I look around for something to save me, when I notice the frozen t.v. dinner in her hand.

"So you're a Salisbury steak lady, eh?" Salisbury steak lady? WHAT IS MY PROBLEM??

"This? Ha. Yeah, I'm an idiot in the kitchen. I screw up Kool-Aid."

"Oh. You're not going to buy that brand, are you?"

"Well...I guess. The commercials make it look decent."

"Ha...ha...yeah, if you like frozen turds'n'gravy." Good. Talk about turds, that'll get her. "Uh...besides, there's a sale on the other brand that doesn't taste so much like..."

"Turds?" She smirks.

"Yes. Here, I've got a coupon that should save you a couple of extra bucks"

"Hey...thanks, Mark."

"No problem."

"You have any other coupons in that little book of yours you don't need?" she asks, leaning over my arm to take a look. Her hair smells like milk and honey.

"Just the feminine hygiene products." CRAP. "Not that...uh...I mean...you don't need hygiene...uh...sorry." I whimpered. I look up and she's red and laughing.

"I think I almost peed. You are too cute. I guess I'd better let you get back to guarding hapless shoppers. I'll see you around, Mark." As she turned and began to walk away, a sense of fear shot through my body. This was as good of a shot as I'd ever get – but I had nothing. I searched frantically for something witty. Something charming. Something suave. Something not me.

"Kristin!"

Crap. She heard me. She turned around.

"Mark?"

I crushed my coupon book under my white knuckles.

"Um...listen...I've got this thing...this 'buy one get one free' coupon for Starbucks...and it expires tomorrow...so I was wondering if you maybe wanted to get some coffee later. If you're not doing anything, that is."

She smiles. "That sounds fantastic."

We swap numbers. As she turns the corner, I open the freezer door and upon seeing my breath, I realize that I have – in fact – survived hell freezing over.

We meet later that evening at Starbucks. As we sit and drink, we go back and forth comparing who in the office we like and who we find, as Kristin would call them, 'intolerable butt-heads'. We come to realize that as kids we identified with Tom and Wile E. Coyote – always feeling like screw-ups despite our most brilliant efforts. She rips on my thrifty nature laughs at the idea of hookers handing out vouchers. The conversation leaps from topic to topic, one minute we're talking about politics, history, literature – the next minute we're both trying to figure out how our lives have ended up the way they did. She's smart and funny. Beyond that, she's kind, charming, and almost too perfect. Part of me is darkly worried that this falls under the "too-good-to-be-true" category. That the pieces fit together too easily and the chemistry came too quickly. But there's another part of me that is too dizzy from the evening to care about tomorrow. As I drop her off, I mention as casually as possible that I have coupons for free popcorn and soda at the

nearby movie theatre. We make plans for Friday. When I get home, for the first time in my life, I fall blissfully asleep…free from any mind games or distractions.

*

This pattern takes shape over the next few weeks. I use what I affectionately call my "Bargain Bible" as a way to initiate dates with Kristin. One Saturday we go mini-golfing and get 6 holes for free, on a Wednesday evening we had half-price ballroom dancing lessons while getting our dry cleaning done for 20% off. We even made a date out of getting her oil changed. I'm starting to learn her quirks, habits, and the smell of her laundry detergent. We give each other weird nicknames and inside jokes such as "Marky Mark the Trouser Shark" and "K-Dawg". I find myself constantly thumbing through the coupons and marking when each expires, so I can plan every rendezvous – I'm that good. While we used our guest passes to go to a local Salsa Cook-Off one Sunday, she turns to me and says,

"I really appreciate everything you've done, Mark. You know…taking me out and showing me around. I love our hanging out."

I get lightheaded…

"I mean…you're like a brother to me."

…and my head promptly explodes. The phrase is a cliché. It's a joke. I expect more from her and am almost repulsed more by her turn-of-phrase than the meaning behind it. I quickly respond,

"I love…hanging out with you too."

Apparently I've been sending out the wrong signals as it would seem that "fun dates" to me are synonymous to spending time with her brother. I take this as a sign that it's time to up the ante.

For the next week, I go full force in planning out the most non-siblingesque evening on the face of the earth. Fancy dinner, dancing, flowers, music, carriage rides, the kit and caboodle. The icing on my cake of seduction: two tickets to the opera for which I paid full price. Granted, they nearly broke the bank and her nose may bleed when we get there, but it's the thought that counts, right?

Wrong.

I stop by Kristin's office to tell her the plans I've made when she squeals that some Tool Bag Wonder Boy from two floors up had invited her to the same opera, the same night, right behind the orchestra. I feign my best "Aww gee, that's great" smile, and listen to her chirp about the evening and how excited she is. I slink out of her office, crumpling the tickets in my hand.

*

The rest of the month becomes a whirlwind for Kristin and Tool Bag Wonder Boy. It would appear that he's sunken his skeezy claws into the gazelle's neck and she's just tossing her hair all the while –oblivious to danger and singing- "Oh my gawd! He is *so* much fun!" Needless to say, I've grown bitter. I expected more from her. I thought she was worth the investment. The point of being thrifty is that you know a good investment when you see one. You weigh the costs and the benefits. You research the goods. Compare. Contrast. You hold on to your cards and wait to play your hand – exercise caution. I've spent my entire life as the sensitive, introspective, geeky kid that carried his heart around in a plastic grocery bag disguised as a lunch sack. I've grown tired of getting crushed due to the faulty physics of thin plastics. I invest in a hard, plastic lunchbox. I'm furious with her and even more so at myself. I feel humiliated. I grow disgusted and embarrassed when I see my coupon book laying on the corner of my desk, so I throw it in the trash and pour my stale coffee over it for good measure. Now it seems, I can't even have my man-fit in peace as Kristin pokes her head in the door. I keep staring at my computer screen.

"Hey, how's it going?"

"I'm fine."

"Really? I haven't seen or heard from you in practically forever."

I shrug.

"Did you want to go use up some coupons this week?"

I reply without so much as blinking or turning from the screen, "Can't. Sorry."

She sighs and stands in the door for a few more heavily awkward moments, waiting for me to say anything warm. I'm a stone wall. Impenetrable. There was a time when I couldn't take my eyes off her – now just the sight of her makes me want to vomit.

We both go about our jobs as if we didn't know each other. Sometimes when I walk into a room that she's just left, I smell milk and honey and for a moment I miss her. At nights, I lie awake and dissect my memories – what she would wear, what I would say, all in a vain attempt to pinpoint any blame on my part. Which there's not. At least now, I can go back to my routine.

*

On Sunday I decide to pamper myself and go grocery shopping to let off a little steam. I stop by the freezer to grab some "Cherry Garcia", and see Kristin sniffling by the tv dinners. My first instinct is to high-tail it in the opposite direction – but we make eye contact and she starts bawling even louder. An old woman clutching a container of Metamucil and frozen beans shoots me a dirty look. I walk over to her.

"Hey."

Her eyes are bloodshot, her hair looks as if she's been given a swirlie, and her nose is running as she clutches a wad of tissues. She looks like hell, or at least as close to hell as she could.

"Are you okay?"

"No."

"What happened?"

"I'm so stupid..."

"I know that...what's making you cry?" I say, trying to lighten the mood. She only cries louder.

"I screwed everything up. I'm an idiot. I mean, the guy I was seeing turned out to be a real grade A jerk and I got wrapped up in all of his stupid little games and I should have seen it coming. But I didn't. And I'm stupid. And now you're angry at me."

"You're not stupid and I'm not angry at you." Not now anyway.

"Pssht. Right." She rolls her soaking wet eyes.

"Well I mean, I should be, after all I've taught you and you're buying the brand name frozen turds again. Jesus woman, get a clue."

She laughs.

Her voice cracks as she says, "I'm sorry."

Once again – the moment is right in front of me. This time – without hesitating – I move in to give her a hug, but as I'm inches from her face the cold wind from the freezer tickles her runny nose and she sneezes all over me.

"Hot."

She laughs embarrassed and I apologize for being an ass as we leave the frozen food aisle.

*

I go to work on Monday figuring that with the exception of the awkwardness being lifted, I'm not getting myself involved with that whole mess again. Granted, maybe I'm being a bit extreme, but I think given the circumstances, I can't afford to get my heart stomped on again. I'm a new man. The squirrel has his nuts and he can't just go and toss them out to every pretty gazelle that wanders along. I enter my office – and find virtually every inch wallpapered with coupons. Including the windows. I look closer to see that every coupon reads: I love you. Sitting on my desk is a home-made coupon book, similar to the one I gave my mom in 4th grade for Mother's Day.